



AI GUIDE SERIES · BOOK THREE

AI at Work

Patrick Thomas

AI at Work

*Increase Productivity and Get More Done Without
Working Longer Hours*

AI Guide Series - Book 3

Patrick Thomas

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Artificial intelligence can be a powerful assistant. It should never replace common sense, professional advice, independent verification, or human judgment.

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Introduction: The 5D Work System

The Day Everything Changed

The following is an illustrative composite, not a claim about a documented individual.

It was a Tuesday afternoon, and Sarah had a problem.

She had three reports due by Friday, a staff meeting to plan, forty-seven unread emails, and a presentation that needed to be completely rewritten. Her manager had just asked her to also pull together a competitor analysis by end of week.

Two years earlier, Sarah would have stayed late every night that week. She would have skipped lunch, stressed out, and maybe still missed a deadline.

But on this particular Tuesday, Sarah opened her laptop, pulled up an AI tool, and got to work. By Wednesday afternoon, she had solid drafts of every report, a meeting plan, a cleaned-up inbox, and a clear path to finish the rest of the week without staying late. She left at 5 p.m.

That's what this book is about.

Here's what Sarah actually did, broken into the five moves that made it possible:

She Drafted the three reports by giving AI her rough notes and the structure she needed. She Digested a stack of competitor websites into a two-page summary using Perplexity. She Decided on the meeting agenda by asking AI to prioritize topics by urgency. She Designed a presentation outline in ten minutes instead of two hours. And she Delegated her standard weekly email update to a saved prompt that fills itself in.

Five moves. Five categories. One system. That's the 5D Work System - and by the end of this book, it'll be yours.

Why AI Is Changing the Workplace

Let's be honest: most of us spend a huge chunk of our workday doing things that are necessary but exhausting. Drafting emails. Summarizing long documents. Formatting reports. Pulling together meeting notes. Searching for information we know is buried somewhere.

These tasks are not the reason you were hired. You were hired for your judgment, your relationships, your expertise, and your ideas. But the repetitive work keeps piling up and eating your time.

AI changes that equation.

Modern AI tools can write a first draft in seconds. They can summarize a ten-page report in a paragraph. They can answer questions, brainstorm ideas, clean up data, and create presentations - all while you focus on the parts of your job that actually require a human.

This isn't science fiction. It's available right now, it's affordable, and millions of workers are already using it every single day.

AI Won't Replace You - But Here's the Catch

You've probably heard the phrase: "AI won't replace workers. Workers who use AI will replace workers who don't."

That might feel a little dramatic. But it reflects what's happening in workplaces right now. Used well, AI can shorten some drafting and information-processing tasks. The quality of the result still depends on the person directing, checking, and approving the work.

The good news? These are learnable skills, and results depend on the task, tool, source material, and review process. You don't need to be a tech expert. You don't need to understand how AI works under the hood. You just need to know how to use it. That's exactly what this book teaches you.

What You'll Learn

By the time you finish this book, you'll be able to:

- Write emails, reports, and documents in a fraction of the time
- Run better meetings with AI-generated agendas and summaries
- Research topics, analyze data, and create presentations faster than you thought possible
- Use the right AI tool for each type of task
- Protect yourself and your company by using AI safely
- Build a personal AI system that works for your specific job

This book is organized into five parts, each building on the last. You can read it straight through, or jump to the chapters most relevant to your job right now.

The 5D Work System

The 5D Work System is a practical way to decide where AI can help and where human review belongs:

- **DRAFT** - Create a first version of an email, report, proposal, procedure, or presentation.
- **DIGEST** - Summarize and organize information without treating the summary as a substitute for the source.
- **DECIDE** - Compare options, surface risks, and challenge assumptions while keeping the final decision with a person.
- **DESIGN** - Build a workflow, checklist, template, presentation, or system.
- **DELEGATE** - Reuse approved prompts and carefully automate repetitive steps with clear review points.

Most tasks use more than one D. A meeting workflow might Digest notes, Draft a recap, Decide what needs escalation, Design an action

list, and Delegate reminders. At each chapter opening, the 5D label shows which moves are most relevant.

How to Get the Most from This Book

The best way to use this book is with an AI tool open in front of you. When you see a prompt example, try it. When you read about a workflow, test it on a real task from your own job.

Your judgment, prompting, and review habits can improve with practice. Short, regular sessions are enough to build familiarity without turning every task into an experiment.

You don't have to be perfect at this. You just have to start.

Part One

Chapter 1: What AI Can (and Can't) Do

5D focus: all 5Ds

Your new coworker is very fast, very smart, and a little strange.

Before you can use AI effectively, you need to understand what it actually does - and what it doesn't do.

Think of AI as a fast drafting assistant with broad but imperfect pattern knowledge. Ask it to write something and it'll give you a first draft in seconds. Ask it to summarize a document and it can propose the key points for you to check against the source. Ask it to brainstorm, organize, or explain - it's ready.

But here's the thing about this intern: they've never actually worked at a real job. They've absorbed an enormous amount of information, but they don't know your company, your clients, your industry quirks, or your specific situation - unless you tell them.

That's the key insight of this whole book. AI is powerful, but it needs direction. You are the expert. AI is your tool.

The 9 Things AI Does Well

1. Writing

This is where most people start, and for good reason. AI can write emails, reports, memos, proposals, social media posts, job descriptions, performance reviews, and virtually any other type of professional document. It won't always nail the tone perfectly on the first try - but it gives you a strong draft you can edit, which is almost always faster than starting from scratch.

2. Summarizing

Have a 30-page report you need to understand in the next ten minutes? Drop it into an AI tool and ask for a summary. You can ask for the key points, a one-paragraph overview, or a summary written for a specific audience. This alone can save hours every week.

3. Brainstorming

Stuck on an idea? AI makes an incredible thinking partner. Ask it to generate twenty ideas for a marketing campaign, suggest solutions to a workflow problem, or come up with topics for your next team meeting. You won't use all the ideas, but you'll find gems you never would have thought of alone.

4. Organizing Information

AI can take a messy pile of notes and turn them into a structured outline. It can convert your rambling voice memo into a clean action list. If you have information that's a mess, AI can help you make sense of it.

5. Data Analysis

You don't need to be a data scientist to analyze spreadsheets anymore. AI tools can help you write formulas in Excel and Google Sheets, explain what your data means, identify trends, and even suggest the right chart to tell your story.

6. Creating Images

Need a graphic for a presentation? AI image tools like DALL-E, Midjourney, and Adobe Firefly can generate professional-looking visuals from a text description. These tools can produce quick concept images, but professional, accessible, brand-safe work may still require a designer and appropriate rights review.

7. Creating Presentations

AI can turn your notes or an outline into a full slide deck. It can write speaker notes, suggest slide structures, and help you tell a visual story. Combine AI with tools like Canva or PowerPoint's built-in AI features and building a deck gets a lot less painful.

8. Coding

Even if you've never written a line of code in your life, AI can help you automate repetitive computer tasks, build simple tools, and write scripts that save hours of manual work.

9. Research Assistance

Need to understand a new industry? Want to know the latest thinking on a business strategy? AI can give you a solid overview of almost any topic in minutes. Some tools, like Perplexity, can even search the web in real time to give you current information.

Use With Caution: A Few Extra Notes

Image generation: AI image tools can produce impressive visuals, but check your company's policy before using them in professional materials. Some organizations have restrictions on AI-generated images, and images can sometimes contain copyright or likeness issues. Coding: AI-generated code can save a lot of time, but never run code you don't understand. Even small mistakes in code can create security vulnerabilities or break systems. Research: AI summaries are a great starting point, but always verify facts from original sources before using them in reports, proposals, or presentations.

Where AI Still Fails You

Now for the honest part - because a book that only hypes AI wouldn't be doing you any favors.

- AI can make things up. It's called "hallucination" and it happens more than you'd like. Always verify important facts.

- AI doesn't know your company. Unless you tell it, it doesn't know your processes, your culture, your clients, or your history.
- AI can't read the room. It doesn't know your office politics or the unspoken dynamics of your workplace. Your judgment still matters - a lot.
- AI can be confidently wrong. It sounds authoritative even when it's incorrect. Never assume it's right just because it sounds sure of itself.
- AI is not a therapist, legal advisor, or doctor. It can share information, but don't use it as a substitute for professional advice.

The Golden Rule

AI is a starting point, not a finish line. Always review what it gives you before you send it, publish it, or act on it.

The Human-AI Partnership Mindset

The most successful AI users don't think of AI as a magic button. They think of it as a collaboration.

You bring the context, the judgment, the relationships, and the final decision. AI brings speed, breadth, and tireless availability. Together, you're more powerful than either one alone.

Think of it this way: a great surgeon doesn't replace their skills with a scalpel. They use the scalpel to apply their skills more precisely. AI is your scalpel.

Try This Today

Pick one task you do regularly at work - writing an email, summarizing a document, or preparing for a meeting. Open ChatGPT or Claude and ask it to help you with that task right now. Don't aim for perfection. Just see what happens. That one experiment is how most people go from curious to converted.

Chapter 2: Picking Your Tool

5D focus: DRAFT, DIGEST, DESIGN

Choose for the workflow, the data, and the organization - not the hype.

AI products change quickly. Names, interfaces, limits, pricing, and included features can change after publication. Content in this chapter was last reviewed in August 2026. Before adopting a tool, check its official product page, current plan terms, data controls, retention settings, and your organization's approved-tool list.

General-Purpose Assistants

Tools such as ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini can help with drafting, summarizing, brainstorming, document analysis, and structured reasoning. Their useful differences often involve supported file types, context limits, collaboration features, integrations, privacy controls, and the plans on which a feature is available. Test the same low-risk task in an approved tool and compare accuracy, editing effort, and fit with your workflow.

Workplace Suites

Microsoft 365 Copilot and Gemini for Google Workspace can work inside familiar office applications when the relevant license, administrator settings, and organizational permissions are in place. Integration can reduce copying between systems, but it does not remove the need to check sources, permissions, recipients, formulas, and final documents.

Research and Source-Grounded Tools

Research assistants can search the web and show citations. Notebook-style tools can answer questions about documents you provide. Both can accelerate DIGEST work, but citations may be irrelevant, outdated, or misrepresented. Open the primary source, confirm its date and authority, and check that it supports the claim before relying on it.

The Durable Decision Rule

Choose the tool that is approved for the information involved, works where your team already works, and produces the lowest total effort after verification. A specialized tool is useful only when it improves the completed, reviewed result.

Try This Today

Choose one approved tool and one low-risk task. Record the time spent prompting, reviewing, correcting, and formatting. Compare that total with your usual process. Keep the workflow only if it improves speed or quality without weakening privacy, accuracy, accessibility, or accountability.

Chapter 3: AI Safety You Can't Skip

5D focus: all 5Ds

A few rules protect you, your organization, and the people whose information you handle.

An AI assistant is a third-party system unless your organization has explicitly approved and configured it otherwise. A useful response does not prove that the input was appropriate to share or that the output is accurate.

Rule 1: Follow Policy and Use Approved Tools

Check your employer's AI, records, security, privacy, and acceptable-use policies. Use the approved account and workspace. If no policy exists, ask a manager, privacy lead, security team, or IT department before entering work information.

Rule 2: Minimize and Protect Data

Do not place confidential, proprietary, privileged, personal, regulated, or security-sensitive information in an unapproved system. Removing a name may not adequately de-identify a record; combinations of dates, locations, job titles, diagnoses, or events can identify a person. Share only the minimum information needed and only through an approved tool.

Rule 3: Verify Against Authoritative Sources

AI can invent facts, quotations, citations, calculations, and legal requirements while sounding confident. Trace important claims to current primary sources. Reconcile numbers to the source data, test formulas with known examples, and have the responsible person approve the final work.

Rule 4: Understand Copyright and Ownership

In the United States, copyright protects human-authored expressive elements. The U.S. Copyright Office states that merely providing prompts is not, by itself, sufficient human authorship for copyright protection. Human selection, arrangement, modification, or other expressive contribution may be protectable when it meets the usual standard. Ownership, training-data, trademark, publicity, contract, and international questions can differ, so obtain legal guidance for commercially important or disputed uses.

Do not ask a tool to reproduce protected works or imitate a living artist for commercial publication without an appropriate rights review. Treat AI output as a draft: inspect it for copied language, make meaningful human choices, document sources, and follow organizational policy.

The 5-Point AI Safety Checklist

- Is the tool and account approved for this task and information?
- Did I minimize or remove confidential, personal, privileged, or regulated data?
- Did I verify facts, citations, calculations, formulas, and source support?
- Did a responsible person review for bias, accessibility, policy, and real-world consequences?
- Is a human clearly accountable for approval and use of the final output?

When Not to Use AI

Do not use an unapproved AI system when the task involves restricted data, privileged advice, high-stakes decisions, or actions that cannot be safely reviewed or reversed. AI should not independently make employment, medical, legal, financial, safety, disciplinary, eligibility, or access decisions.

Try This Today

Ask your manager or IT department which tools, accounts, and data types are approved. Save the answer with your team's procedures. If guidance is missing, use only public or invented information until a policy and review path exist.

Part Two

Chapter 4: The Prompting Formula

5D focus: all 5Ds

The difference between a mediocre AI response and an amazing one is almost always how you asked.

Imagine you walk up to a new employee and say, "Write something about the budget."

What do you get back? Who knows. Maybe a budget summary. Maybe a budget proposal. Maybe a poem about money. You gave them nothing to work with.

Now imagine you say: "You're our finance manager. Write a one-page summary of our Q3 budget performance for our board meeting. Focus on the three biggest variances from the plan. Keep it professional but not overly technical. Use bullet points for the key findings."

That's a different story entirely. This is the art of prompting - and it's the single most important skill in this entire book.

5D Connection

Prompting is the engine behind every D in the 5D Work System. Whether you're Drafting an email, Digesting a report, Deciding between options, Designing a workflow, or Delegating a task to a saved template - a well-written prompt is what makes the difference between a useful result and a frustrating one.

The Formula: Role + Task + Context + Requirements + Format + Example

A strong prompt may use six ingredients. Include the details that improve the task, but do not add sensitive data. More context is useful only when it is relevant, permitted, and accurate.

Role - Tell AI who to be

Start your prompt by assigning a role. This sets the tone, expertise level, and perspective for the entire response.

Example:

"You are an experienced HR manager at a mid-sized tech company..."

Task - Say exactly what you want

Be specific. Don't say "write an email." Say "write a follow-up email to a client who hasn't responded in two weeks."

Example:

"Write a three-paragraph executive summary of the following report..."

Context - Give the background

The more relevant background you provide, the more accurate the output. Who is the audience? What's the situation? What has already happened?

Example:

"Our team just finished a major project that came in under budget. The client is happy but we had some communication challenges along the way..."

Requirements - Set the rules

Tell AI what to include or avoid. Do you want a formal tone or casual? Should it avoid jargon? Are there specific points that must be covered?

Example:

"Avoid technical jargon. Include specific next steps. Don't mention the budget dispute."

Format - Specify the output structure

Should the response be a bulleted list? A table? Three paragraphs? An outline? Telling AI the format prevents you from getting a wall of text when you wanted a quick list.

Example:

"Format this as a short email with a subject line, three bullet points, and a call to action at the end."

Example - Show AI what good looks like

This is the most underused element. If you have an example of the tone, style, or structure you want, share it. Even a sentence or two from a previous email you liked can dramatically improve the result.

Example:

"Use the same tone and structure as this sample I wrote: [paste example]. Match the level of formality and the paragraph length."

Putting It All Together

Full Prompt Example:

You are an experienced project manager. [ROLE] Write a project status update email to our executive team. [TASK] We are three weeks into a six-week website redesign. We're on schedule, but we just discovered a technical issue that might add two days to the timeline. [CONTEXT] Keep the tone professional but not alarming. Be honest without being overly detailed. [REQUIREMENTS] Format it as a short email with a subject line, a two-sentence summary, and three bullet points covering status, the issue, and next steps. [FORMAT] Here is an example of a status update email I sent last month that had the right tone: [paste example]. Match that style. [EXAMPLE]

The 3 Most Common Prompting Mistakes

Mistake 1: Being Too Vague

"Help me with my presentation" tells AI almost nothing. "Create a 10-slide outline for a 20-minute sales presentation introducing our new software product to small business owners who have never used project management software" - now we're talking.

Mistake 2: Not Iterating

The first response you get is almost never the final product. Treat AI like a conversation. If the tone is wrong, say so: "Make this less formal." If it's too long: "Cut this in half." Iterate until it's right.

Mistake 3: Copying Without Reviewing

Never send AI output without reading it first. Not because AI is usually wrong, but because this is your name on it. Own it.

Try This Today

Take a prompt you've already used with AI - or write a simple one now - and run it twice. First time: just describe the task with no formula. Second time: add a role, context, requirements, format, and an example. Compare the two results side by side. The difference will convince you faster than any explanation could.

Chapter 5: Email in Half the Time

5D focus: DRAFT

The task that eats your day - finally tamed.

This chapter is about the first D - Draft. Email is where most people spend the most time creating written content from scratch. Mastering AI-assisted email drafting is often the single fastest win in the entire 5D system.

Illustrative Scenario

BEFORE: Marcus, an operations manager, spent about 45 minutes every morning working through his email backlog. Writing replies, thinking through tone, crafting difficult messages - it was slow, draining work that left him behind before the real day even started.

AFTER: Marcus now spends 15 minutes on email each morning. He pastes difficult emails into Claude, describes what he wants to say, and edits the draft. For routine emails, he uses saved prompts. In this example, he produces review-ready drafts faster, with less mental energy spent on words and more on actual decisions.

Email can consume a large share of the workday, especially when every response starts from a blank page.

AI may reduce drafting time for routine messages. Not by ignoring emails, but by handling the drafting, formatting, and thinking that takes so long.

Safety Reminder

Before pasting any email into an AI tool, ask yourself: does this contain confidential client information, sensitive employee data, or anything governed by your company's privacy policy? If yes, remove that information first or use an AI tool your organization has approved for sensitive data.

Writing Emails from Scratch

Instead of staring at a blank screen, give AI the situation and let it draft for you.

Write a professional email to a new vendor introducing our company and asking for a product catalog and pricing. We're a 50-person manufacturing company looking to source industrial cleaning supplies. Keep it concise and professional.

You'll get a complete draft in seconds. Read it, tweak anything that doesn't sound like you, and send. For many straightforward emails, the whole process takes just a couple of minutes.

Replying Professionally

When you receive a difficult email and aren't sure how to respond, paste it into AI and ask for help.

Here is an email I received from a client who is unhappy with a delayed delivery: [PASTE EMAIL HERE] Write a professional response that acknowledges their frustration, uses our approved service-recovery policy, avoids legal admissions or commitments, and flags anything that needs manager or legal review, explains what happened briefly, and offers a 10% discount on their next order.

Improving Tone

Sometimes you write a draft that says the right things but sounds harsh or cold. AI is excellent at tone repair.

Rewrite this email to sound warmer and more collaborative, while keeping the same key information: [PASTE YOUR DRAFT]

Shortening Emails

Long emails don't get read. AI can trim the fat instantly.

Shorten this email to under 100 words without losing the key message:
[PASTE YOUR EMAIL]

Handling Difficult Conversations

Nobody loves writing the email that delivers bad news or sets a firm boundary. AI can help you strike exactly the right tone.

Write an email declining a meeting request from a colleague who wants 90 minutes of my time for a project I'm not involved in. Be polite but firm. Offer a 15-minute call as an alternative if it's truly urgent.

Follow-Up Emails

The follow-up email is awkward for almost everyone. AI makes it easy.

Write a follow-up email to a client I met with two weeks ago. I sent them a proposal but haven't heard back. Be friendly and low-pressure. Ask if they have questions and let them know I'm happy to jump on a call.

10 Ready-to-Use Email Templates

- 1 "Write an email requesting [deadline extension / meeting / approval] from [my manager / client / vendor]. The situation is: [CONTEXT]."
- 2 "Write a thank-you email after [job interview / meeting / presentation]. Mention specifically: [DETAIL]."
- 3 "Write an out-of-office reply for [dates]. I'll be back on [date]. Urgent matters should go to [NAME]."
- 4 "Write an introduction email connecting [PERSON A] and [PERSON B] who both work in [INDUSTRY] because [REASON]."
- 5 "Write an email announcing [COMPANY NEWS] to our team. Keep it positive, clear, and include key details: [DETAILS]."

- 6 "Write a professional email requesting a raise. I've been in this role for [TIME] and recently accomplished [ACHIEVEMENT]."
- 7 "Write a cold outreach email to [TARGET]. I want to [GOAL]. Keep it brief and not salesy."
- 8 "Write a response to an angry customer email. The complaint is about [ISSUE]. I want to offer [SOLUTION]."
- 9 "Write an email to my team about an upcoming change to [PROCESS]. Frame it positively and invite questions."
- 10 "Write a meeting invitation for [MEETING TYPE] on [DATE]. Attendees: [NAMES]. Agenda: [AGENDA]."

Try This Today

Find one email sitting in your drafts folder or on your mental to-do list that you've been avoiding writing. Open an AI tool, describe the situation in two or three sentences, and ask it to write a first draft. Edit it until it sounds like you, then send it. Notice how much faster that was.

Chapter 6: Meetings That Actually Move Work Forward

5D focus: DIGEST, DRAFT, DELEGATE

Stop spending half your week in meetings that could have been an email.

Meetings are primarily a Digest challenge. Your job is to turn a room full of conversation into clear decisions and action items. AI doesn't attend your meetings - but it processes the output faster than anyone in the room.

Illustrative Scenario

BEFORE: Jennifer managed a team of eight and ran three recurring meetings a week. After each one, writing up the notes and action items took 30-45 minutes - time she didn't have. Things fell through the cracks. Follow-through was inconsistent. **AFTER:** Jennifer takes rough bullet points during each meeting, pastes them into ChatGPT immediately after, and has a clean summary with owners and due dates in two minutes. She sends it before she's even left the conference room. Her team now says the follow-through has never been better - and Jennifer saved nearly two hours a week without changing how she runs the meetings.

Most meetings have two problems: they're too long, and nothing happens afterward. AI can solve both.

Before: Creating an Agenda

A clear agenda can make a meeting more focused. AI can help draft one quickly, but the organizer must set the purpose, priorities, and participants.

Create a 45-minute team meeting agenda for a weekly project check-in. Topics: progress updates, one unresolved technical issue, and planning for next week. Include time allocations for each section and a 5-minute buffer for questions.

During: Taking Notes

Several tools - including Microsoft Copilot in Teams, Otter.ai, and Fireflies.ai - can join your meeting and take notes automatically. If you're in an in-person meeting, use an organization-approved recording or note-taking method only after confirming applicable consent law, workplace policy, participant notice, and authorization. Do not record or upload privileged, personnel, medical, customer, or other restricted content without explicit approval. Even rough bullet points jotted during the meeting can be transformed in minutes.

After: Summarizing the Meeting

Here are my raw notes from a 1-hour project meeting: [PASTE YOUR NOTES] Create a clean meeting summary including: key decisions made, open questions, and action items with owners and due dates.

The 15-Minute Post-Meeting AI Workflow

- 11 Right after the meeting, spend 5 minutes jotting down bullet points of everything discussed.
- 12 Paste your notes into AI and ask for a meeting summary with decisions and action items.
- 13 Use AI to draft the follow-up email to all attendees.
- 14 Copy the action items into your task management tool.
- 15 Done. Total time: 15 minutes. The reviewed recap gives participants a clearer record of what was decided and who owns each confirmed action.

Pro Tip

Send the AI-generated summary to attendees within 30 minutes of the meeting ending. This simple habit builds your reputation as someone who gets things done - and eliminates the endless 'wait, what did we decide?' confusion.

Try This Today

After your next meeting, spend five minutes jotting down bullet points of what was discussed. Paste them into an AI tool with this prompt: 'Turn these rough meeting notes into a clean summary with key decisions and action items with owners.' Check the recap against your notes, confirm recipients and permissions, and then share it through the approved channel.

Chapter 7: Reports and Documents

5D focus: DRAFT, DESIGN

From rough notes to polished documents - without the pain.

Reports and documents are Draft territory - but they're the heavy lifting version. These aren't quick emails. They're the documents that get read by executives, sent to clients, and used to make real decisions. The same formula applies, but the stakes are higher and the prep work matters more.

Reports, proposals, SOPs, policies - these are the documents that run organizations. They also take forever to write. Not anymore.

Before You Ask AI to Write Any Report - Answer These 5 Questions First

- 1 Who is the audience, and what do they already know?
 - 2 What decision will this report support?
 - 3 What data or facts must be included?
 - 4 What recommendation or conclusion do you want to make?
 - 5 What facts need to be verified before going in?
- Give AI the answers to these questions as part of your prompt and your output will be dramatically more useful.

Reports

The key to great AI-assisted reports is giving AI a clear structure. Don't just say "write a report about our sales performance." Give it the shape:

Write a monthly sales performance report for November. Structure: 1. Executive Summary (3-4 sentences) 2. Key Metrics (table: Revenue, Units Sold, New Customers, Conversion Rate) 3. What Went Well (3 bullet points) 4. Challenges (2-3 bullet points) 5. Recommendations for December (3 action items) Here are the numbers: [PASTE YOUR DATA]

Standard Operating Procedures

Write a standard operating procedure for onboarding a new remote employee. Include: pre-start preparation, day one schedule, week one checklist, 30-day milestones. Format as numbered steps for a manager to verify against current policy before sharing with a new hire.

Proposals

Write a business proposal for upgrading our customer service software. Audience: executive team. Include: the problem we're solving, proposed solution, expected benefits, estimated costs, implementation timeline, and recommended next step. Tone: professional and persuasive.

Executive Summaries

The executive summary is the most-read part of any long report. It needs to be tight, clear, and compelling. It's also often the hardest to write.

Here is a 10-page report: [PASTE REPORT]. Write a one-page executive summary for senior leadership. Focus on the three most important findings and the single most important recommendation.

Editing Existing Documents

Here is a draft report I've written: [PASTE DOCUMENT]. Please: 1) Improve clarity and flow, 2) Tighten any sections that are too wordy, 3) Suggest a stronger opening paragraph.

Before and After

Before AI: 2-3 hours writing a proposal from scratch, then more time editing. With AI: 15 minutes describing what you need, 10-20 minutes editing the draft, a few minutes polishing. For many people, AI cuts document writing time by half or more - and the drafts are often

stronger because you spend your energy editing rather than staring at a blank page.

Try This Today

Find a report, memo, or document you need to write this week. Before opening a blank page, answer the five pre-report questions above. Then give AI your answers as the starting prompt. Compare how that draft compares to one you'd write cold.

Part Three

Chapter 8: Office Professionals

5D focus: DRAFT, DESIGN, DECIDE

How AI transforms everyday office work.

Office professionals live in Draft and Design territory. You're constantly creating written content (Draft) and building systems, templates, and processes that help your organization run (Design). This chapter covers both.

Illustrative Scenario

BEFORE: Diana, an executive assistant, spent two hours each Monday preparing briefing documents, drafting her executive's correspondence, and summarizing reports that had landed over the weekend. AFTER: Diana uses a saved prompt to generate briefing documents from a set of bullet points, another prompt to draft correspondence in her executive's voice, and drops PDFs into Claude to get five-bullet summaries in under a minute. Her Monday prep now takes 35 minutes. She spends the rest of the morning on the work that actually requires her judgment.

Whether you're an administrative assistant, a manager, an HR professional, a finance analyst, or a customer service rep, AI has tools built specifically for your work.

Administrative Assistants

- Draft and format correspondence and memos in seconds
- Create meeting agendas and post-meeting summaries automatically
- Build templates for recurring documents so you're never starting from scratch
- Research vendors, venues, or travel options with AI-assisted summaries

- Organize notes from multiple sources into a clean briefing document

Admin Prompt:

I'm preparing a briefing document for my executive's meeting with a potential partner. Here's what I know: [DETAILS]. Create a one-page brief covering: company background, key people, what they do, why this meeting matters, and three suggested talking points.

Managers

- Write performance review drafts based on bullet points you provide
- Create team communication emails that are clear and motivating
- Build structured one-on-one meeting agendas
- Draft job descriptions, offer letter templates, and onboarding documents
- Analyze options and build decision frameworks

Manager Prompt:

I need to write a performance review for an employee who had a strong year overall but struggled with meeting deadlines. My notes: [NOTES]. Write a balanced, professional review that acknowledges their strengths, addresses the deadline concern constructively, and sets clear expectations for next year.

Human Resources

Use only approved criteria, templates, and systems. Do not enter identifying employee or applicant data into a public AI tool. AI may help organize job-related evidence, but managers remain responsible for accuracy, consistency, nondiscrimination, reasonable-accommodation considerations, and compliance with employment law and organizational policy. Performance reviews, interview questions, discipline, and improvement plans require qualified human review.

- Write and update job descriptions that attract the right candidates
- Draft employee communication about policy changes or benefits updates
- Create structured interview question sets for different roles
- Build onboarding checklists and training outlines
- Write HR policy documents and employee handbook sections

HR Prompt:

Write a job description for a mid-level marketing manager at a technology company. Include: role summary, 8-10 key responsibilities, required qualifications, preferred qualifications, and a short company culture statement. Tone: professional but welcoming.

Finance

- Translate complex financial data into plain-English narratives
- Draft financial reports with clear executive summaries
- Create budget proposals with supporting rationale
- Build formulas in Excel with AI assistance
- Write variance explanations that are clear and defensible

Customer Service

- Build a template library for the 20 most common customer issues
- Rewrite angry customer emails in a way that de-escalates and resolves
- Create FAQ documents and knowledge base articles from existing tickets
- Draft escalation scripts for difficult calls

Customer Service Prompt:

Here are 10 common customer complaints we receive: [LIST]. Create a professional, empathetic response template for each one. Include a place to insert the customer's name and specific situation details.

Try This Today

Think of one low-risk document you create at work that follows a familiar pattern - a weekly status update, meeting recap, or client report. Write an AI prompt that generates a first draft, test it with non-sensitive information, and save the approved version. You have reduced part of a repetitive task while keeping review and accountability with a person.

Chapter 9: Teachers and Healthcare Workers

5D focus: DRAFT, DIGEST, DESIGN

Two professions with massive paper loads - and a new way to manage them.

Teachers

Safety boundary: Check district and IT approval before using AI. Do not enter student records or personally identifiable information into an unapproved tool. Ground lessons and quizzes in approved curriculum sources, check accessibility and age appropriateness, and have the teacher verify every answer.

Teachers spend hours outside the classroom on work that never shows up in a grade book. AI can cut this time significantly.

Important for Teachers

Before using AI tools in your school work, check your district's policy on AI. Many districts have guidelines about which tools are approved and what types of information can be shared. Never enter student names, grades, behavioral records, or any personally identifiable student information into a public AI tool. This is both a privacy best practice and, in many cases, a legal requirement under FERPA and similar laws.

Lesson Plans

Create a 50-minute lesson plan for 9th grade English introducing persuasive writing. Include: learning objectives, warm-up (5 min), direct instruction (15 min), guided practice (20 min), independent practice (8 min), and closing reflection (2 min). Engaging, appropriate for mixed ability levels.

Practice Quizzes and Study Guides

Based on this chapter about the American Civil War: [PASTE CONTENT]. Create a 15-question multiple choice quiz with an answer key, and a one-page study guide with the 10 most important concepts.

Parent Communications

Write a professional but warm email to parents explaining we'll be covering a challenging historical topic next week: [TOPIC]. Include: why we're covering it, how it will be taught with sensitivity, what parents can expect, and how they can support conversations at home.

Healthcare Workers

Safety boundary: Use AI with patient information only in an organization-approved system that has completed privacy and security review and, when required, an appropriate vendor agreement. Removing a name alone may not de-identify a record. A qualified clinician must verify documentation and patient-facing content. AI must not diagnose, prescribe, or make independent care decisions.

Important disclaimer: AI is not a substitute for medical judgment, clinical training, or licensed professional advice. The applications here are about documentation, communication, and education - not diagnosis or treatment.

HIPAA and Healthcare AI

Healthcare organizations are subject to HIPAA and other privacy regulations that strictly govern how patient information can be shared or processed. Never enter patient names, diagnoses, treatment details, or any protected health information (PHI) into a public AI tool. Only use AI tools that your organization has specifically reviewed and approved for clinical or administrative use. When in doubt, consult your compliance officer before using any AI tool for work-related tasks.

Documentation

Healthcare workers spend enormous time on documentation. AI can help convert rough notes into structured documentation formats.

Using only notes entered into our approved clinical system, organize this information into a draft SOAP structure. Mark missing information as 'not provided,' do not infer diagnoses or findings, and flag contradictions for clinician review: [APPROVED NOTES]

Patient Education Materials

Write a one-page patient education handout explaining [CONDITION/PROCEDURE]. Write at a 6th grade reading level. Include: what it is, what to expect, how to prepare, and who to call with questions. Friendly, reassuring tone.

Administrative Work

From scheduling communications to staff memos to policy updates, administrative healthcare writing is a significant burden. Everything in the Office Professionals chapter applies here - the same prompting approach cuts administrative writing time in half.

Try This Today

Teachers: write your next parent communication using AI. Give it the topic, the grade level, your school name, and the tone you want. Edit it until it sounds like you. Healthcare workers: try converting one set of rough notes into a structured format. See how much time it saves compared to writing it from scratch.

Chapter 10: Trades, Field Workers & Small Business Owners

5D focus: DRAFT, DESIGN, DECIDE

AI isn't just for office workers.

Tradespeople and small business owners often spend as much time on paperwork as they do on the actual job. Estimates, scopes, checklists, emails, social posts - that's all Draft and Design work. AI handles it so you can stay focused on the work you're actually good at.

Illustrative Scenario

BEFORE: Carlos ran a five-person electrical contracting company. He was good at the work but hated the paperwork. Writing up scopes of work took an hour each. Estimates took longer. He'd lose jobs because he was slow getting proposals back to clients - not because his price was wrong. AFTER: Carlos describes the job in plain language, pastes it into ChatGPT, and gets a draft scope of work more quickly. He uses an approved pricing template, checks every figure and term, and can prepare a reviewed proposal sooner. In this example, the faster workflow helps him respond to prospective clients sooner; it does not guarantee that he will win the work.

Here's a misconception worth busting: AI tools aren't just for people who sit at desks. If you run a plumbing business, manage a construction crew, own a restaurant, or work in the field - AI can make your life significantly easier.

Trades and Field Workers

Scope of Work Documents

Start from an approved template. Check scope, exclusions, permits, code requirements, warranties, payment terms, and change-order language with the appropriate local, technical, and legal reviewers before giving the document to a customer.

Write a detailed scope of work for a residential bathroom renovation. Include: project description, materials and labor included, what is excluded, timeline, payment schedule, and warranty terms. Professional enough to give directly to a homeowner.

Safety Checklists

AI may format a checklist only from approved site procedures, current regulations, manufacturer instructions, and competent-person input. A qualified person must review it before use; a generated checklist never replaces training, hazard assessment, permits, lockout/tagout, or required supervision.

Create a daily pre-work safety checklist for a commercial electrical crew on new construction. Include categories for: personal protective equipment, tools and equipment inspection, work area setup, communication, and emergency procedures.

Inspection Reports

Use AI to organize approved observations and criteria, not to invent findings or assign severity, compliance status, or remediation. Those judgments belong to a qualified inspector or competent person.

Using only these approved field observations and the supplied inspection criteria, format a draft report with an executive summary and findings by category. Preserve the inspector's assigned ratings and remediation language exactly; mark any missing rating or action as 'not provided': [APPROVED NOTES AND CRITERIA].

Change Orders

Write a professional change order document for a [TYPE OF PROJECT]. The original scope was [ORIGINAL SCOPE]. The change being requested is [CHANGE DESCRIPTION]. The reason for the change is [REASON]. The additional cost is \$[AMOUNT] and the impact on the timeline is [TIMELINE IMPACT]. Format it so a client can sign and return it.

Before and After Job Reports

Write a brief before-and-after job summary for a [TYPE OF JOB] I just completed for a client. Before: [DESCRIBE THE PROBLEM OR STARTING CONDITION]. After: [DESCRIBE WHAT WAS DONE AND THE RESULT]. Make it professional and suitable for following up with the client or posting as a testimonial request.

Google Business Profile Posts

Write a short Google Business Profile post for my [TYPE OF BUSINESS] highlighting a recent [JOB TYPE] project I completed in [CITY/AREA]. Keep it under 150 words, mention the service, the location, and end with a call to action encouraging people to call or request a quote.

Small Business Owners

Running a small business means wearing every hat. AI can assist with selected drafting and analysis tasks, but it does not replace professional expertise, current local data, or the owner's judgment.

Marketing Content

Write 5 social media posts for my [TYPE OF BUSINESS]. Each post should highlight a different service, include a call to action, and match this brand voice: [DESCRIBE]. Keep each post under 150 words.

Customer Emails and Newsletters

Write a monthly email newsletter for my landscaping business. Include: a seasonal tip for homeowners, a feature on one of our services, a brief customer testimonial placeholder, and a special offer for the month. Friendly and professional.

Business Planning and Pricing

AI can organize assumptions and scenarios, but pricing and business recommendations need current local costs, market evidence, tax and legal considerations, and owner judgment.

I'm considering adding [NEW SERVICE] to my business. Help me think through: the target customer, how to price it competitively, startup costs, how to market it, and the biggest risks to consider.

Website Content

Write the homepage content for a [TYPE OF BUSINESS] serving [LOCATION]. Include: a headline, subheadline, short 'About Us' paragraph, a services section with 5 service descriptions (2-3 sentences each), and a call-to-action. Tone: [PROFESSIONAL / FRIENDLY / ENERGETIC].

Try This Today

Pick one document you write repeatedly for clients or customers - an estimate, a follow-up email, a scope of work, a job summary. Use AI to create a template version with [BRACKETS] for the parts that change each time. Save it. The next time you need that document, fill in the brackets and you're done in minutes instead of starting from scratch.

Part Four

Chapter 11: Research and Data, Fast

5D focus: DIGEST, DECIDE

Turn hours of digging into minutes of insight.

Research and data are the heart of the Digest stage. Your job isn't to read everything - it's to understand what matters. AI compresses the reading and surfaces the signal, so you can spend your energy on the analysis and decisions only you can make.

Illustrative Scenario

BEFORE: Priya, a marketing analyst, spent three to four hours each week reading industry reports, competitor blogs, and research papers to stay current and prepare for strategy meetings. Most of it she skimmed, felt guilty about, and never used. AFTER: Priya uploads documents to Claude and asks for five-bullet summaries. She uses Perplexity for real-time industry updates. Her weekly research now takes 45 minutes and she arrives at meetings with sharper insights than before - because she's spending her time thinking about the information rather than just collecting it.

Research: Faster and Broader - But Still Verify

Research used to mean hours of reading, tabbing between browser windows, and trying to synthesize information from a dozen different sources. AI tools have made this significantly faster. But speed doesn't remove the need to verify. Think of AI as your first pass - it gets you oriented quickly. Your job is to confirm the most important facts before you use them.

Summarizing Long Documents

Drop any long document into Claude or ChatGPT and ask for a summary. You can ask for different types:

Summary Prompts:

"Summarize this 20-page report in 5 bullet points for a CEO who has 2 minutes." "Summarize this document and identify the 3 most important recommendations." "Summarize this article for someone who knows nothing about this industry." "What are the key arguments the author is making, and do they support them well?"

Industry and Competitor Research

A current-web research tool can help locate sources, but its summary and citations can still be wrong. Open the primary sources, confirm their dates and authority, and verify that each source supports the claim.

Research Prompts:

"What are the top 5 trends shaping the [INDUSTRY] industry right now?" "Compare [COMPANY A] and [COMPANY B] on: products, pricing, market position, and recent news." "What are the biggest challenges facing [INDUSTRY] and how are leading companies responding?"

Data: Excel and Google Sheets Without the Pain

Data Safety Reminder

Before pasting spreadsheet data into an AI tool, ask yourself: does this contain confidential sales figures, customer data, employee information, payroll, or any data your company classifies as sensitive? If yes, remove identifying information first, or use an AI tool your organization has specifically approved for this type of data.

You don't need to be an Excel expert to use Excel like one. AI can write formulas for you, explain what they do, and help you build entire spreadsheet systems.

Getting Formulas Written for You

I have a spreadsheet tracking monthly sales. Column A is the month, Column B is total sales, Column C is returns. I want Column D to show net sales, Column E to show if we hit our \$50,000 monthly goal (yes/no), and Column F to show the percentage change from the previous month. Write the Excel formulas for each column.

Understanding Your Data

Here is my sales data for the last 12 months: [PASTE DATA]. Identify the top 3 trends, any unusual months, and give me 3 recommendations based on the patterns you see.

Data Cleanup

I have customer data with problems: some names are in ALL CAPS, some have extra spaces, phone numbers are in different formats, and some email addresses appear invalid. Write Excel formulas to standardize the name capitalization, remove extra spaces, and flag emails that don't contain '@'.

Charts and Visual Storytelling

AI can tell you exactly which chart type best communicates your data - and why.

I have monthly revenue data for 3 products over 2 years. I'm presenting to a board that needs to quickly see which product is growing and which is declining. What type of chart should I use, and what should I highlight?

Try This Today

Find a spreadsheet you use regularly that has a formula you've always found confusing or had to look up. Paste the formula into AI and ask it to explain exactly what it does in plain English. Then ask it to suggest a better or simpler version if one exists. You'll understand your own data better in five minutes than you might have in years of guessing.

Chapter 12: Automate the Repetitive Stuff

5D focus: DELEGATE, DESIGN

Stop doing the same task twice.

This is the fifth D - and for many people, the most powerful one. Delegation used to mean handing work to another person. Now it means building AI systems that handle your most repetitive tasks automatically. You build and test it, then reuse it with periodic review as tools, policies, and business needs change.

Illustrative Scenario

BEFORE: Tom managed customer onboarding at a software company. Every new client got the same series of emails - welcome message, setup instructions, first check-in, 30-day follow-up. Tom wrote each one individually. It was copy-paste work that still somehow took 20 minutes per client. AFTER: Tom built a prompt library with six saved onboarding email templates. He fills in the client name and a few specifics, and the emails are done in two minutes total. He also created custom instructions in ChatGPT that remember his company's tone and the product details, so he never re-explains the context. In this example, the saved templates handle much of his routine drafting. He uses the saved time for client calls that actually require a human.

What do you do at work over and over again? Maybe it's writing the same type of email every week. Maybe it's formatting a monthly report. Maybe it's answering the same customer questions with the same answers.

Whatever it is, AI can help you stop doing it manually - and start doing it in seconds.

Build a Prompt Library

A prompt library is simply a saved collection of your best prompts. Instead of writing a new prompt every time you need a specific type of document, you pull up your saved prompt, fill in the specifics, and go.

Start with your five to ten most common work tasks. Write a great prompt for each one. Save them in a document or note. That's your prompt library.

Quick Win

Create a document called "My AI Prompts" and add to it every time you write a prompt you might want to use again. Within a month, you can have a personal toolkit that reduces repeated setup work.

Create Reusable Templates

Combine AI with approved document templates: generate a draft, verify its facts and terms, place it in the template, and complete the required human review.

Example: You have a monthly client report template in Word. Instead of writing the content every month, you feed AI the month's data and ask it to fill in each section. You copy-paste into your template. Total time: ten minutes for something that used to take three hours.

Building Your Personal AI Assistant

Some assistants offer saved instructions or project workspaces. Availability and controls vary by product and plan. Do not place employer, product, customer, or confidential details in a personal or public workspace unless your organization has approved that account and use.

Custom Instructions

In ChatGPT, go to Settings \> Personalization \> Custom Instructions. Here you can tell ChatGPT who you are, what you do, and how you want it to respond - permanently. It applies to every conversation.

Example Custom Instructions:

I'm a marketing manager at a B2B software company with about 200 employees. I mostly need help with writing, data analysis, and strategic thinking. Always write in a professional but accessible tone. When I ask for content, give me a draft I can edit, not a list of suggestions. Don't add unnecessary caveats unless they're truly important.

Projects

Both ChatGPT and Claude offer a Projects feature that lets you store documents, instructions, and conversation history in one organized space. Create a project for each major area of your work. Each project remembers the context you've given it. This is the closest thing to having an AI that actually knows your job. Use it.

Your Weekly AI Work System

The goal isn't to use AI for everything. It's to build a simple routine that removes friction from the most repetitive parts of your week. Here's a starting framework you can adapt to your own job:

A Simple Weekly AI Routine

MONDAY - Use AI to review your week's priorities and draft any important emails or communications you need to send. **DAILY** - Use AI for email drafts, document edits, and quick research. Keep a prompt or two saved for your most common tasks. **AFTER MEETINGS** - Use AI to turn your rough notes into a clean summary and action items within 30 minutes. **FRIDAY** - Use AI to write a brief summary of what you accomplished this week and what's waiting on Monday. This takes five minutes and makes Monday morning much less chaotic. **As needed** - Use AI for research, data analysis, presentations, job-specific documents, and anything else from this book.

Start with just one of these. Once it becomes a habit, add another. Within a month you'll have a routine that saves hours every week.

Try This Today

Write your custom instructions for ChatGPT or Claude right now. Open Settings, find Custom Instructions or similar, and fill in: your job title, what you mostly use AI for, your preferred tone, and any standing preferences. That's the single fastest way to improve every AI response you get from this point forward.

Chapter 13: AI Inside Your Favorite Apps

5D focus: all 5Ds

Content last reviewed: August 2026. Features, names, licensing, and administrator controls vary by product and plan; check official documentation and your organization's approved configuration.

Your existing tools just got a serious upgrade.

This chapter is about accessing the entire 5D system without leaving the apps you already use. When AI is built into your tools, every D becomes available without switching context or learning something new.

You don't always have to switch to a dedicated AI tool. Many of the apps you already use have AI built right in - or have integrations that bring AI directly to your workflow.

Microsoft 365 - Copilot

If your organization has Microsoft 365 Copilot, AI lives inside Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook, and Teams.

- Word: Highlight text and ask Copilot to rewrite, summarize, or expand it
- Excel: Ask Copilot to analyze your data in plain English - no formulas required
- PowerPoint: Describe what you need and Copilot builds a starting deck
- Outlook: Copilot summarizes long email threads and drafts replies
- Teams: Copilot takes meeting notes and creates action item summaries in real time

Google Workspace - Gemini

- Gmail: Use "Help me write" to draft emails from a brief description
- Docs: Ask Gemini to write, summarize, or reformat content
- Sheets: Ask questions about your data in natural language
- Slides: Generate slides from an outline automatically

Notion AI

If your team uses Notion, Notion AI is built in and excellent. It can summarize pages, generate content, create action items from meeting notes, and fill in templates automatically.

Canva AI

Canva's AI features let you generate images, remove backgrounds, resize designs for different platforms, write copy for graphics, and create entire presentation decks from a text description.

Slack AI

For teams using Slack, Slack AI can summarize channels you missed, recap long threads, and help you catch up on conversations quickly without reading every message.

The Bigger Picture

You do not need to master every AI tool. Focus on the approved platforms where you already work, and evaluate whether their AI features improve the completed, reviewed result.

Important: Check Your Organization's License

Many of the AI features described in this chapter - Microsoft Copilot, Gemini for Workspace, Notion AI, Slack AI - require paid business plans or administrator-level access. Before assuming you have access to these features, check with your IT department or manager. Some features may need to be enabled by an administrator, or your organization may have approved a different set of tools.

Try This Today

Open one app you use every day - Outlook, Word, Gmail, Docs, or Slack. Look for an AI or Copilot or 'Help me write' button anywhere in the interface. If you find one, try it on a real task right now. You may already have AI built into a tool you've been using for years.

Part Five

Chapter 14: The Future of Work - And Your Place In It

5D focus: DECIDE, DELEGATE

The world is changing. Here's how to stay ahead.

Most people use AI to Draft and Digest. Fewer use it to Decide. But AI is a remarkably good thinking partner for decisions: it doesn't have office politics, it doesn't get tired, and it will challenge your assumptions if you ask it to. As AI gets more powerful, the workers who use it for strategic thinking - not just document production - will have a significant advantage.

Let's talk honestly about where all of this is going.

AI is not slowing down. The tools you use today will be more powerful in twelve months than they are right now. Things that currently require human effort - scheduling, basic analysis, routine communications, data entry - will become increasingly automated.

This isn't a reason to panic. It's a reason to prepare.

AI Agents: The Next Wave

Right now, AI is a tool you use - you type in a prompt, it gives you output. That's already powerful. The next wave is AI agents: AI that doesn't just respond to prompts but takes actions on your behalf. These systems may be able to browse the web, draft or send messages, update files, schedule events, and complete multi-step tasks, depending on their permissions and configuration.

We're in the early stages of this right now. OpenAI has built agent capabilities directly into ChatGPT, Microsoft and Google are rolling out similar systems, and a growing number of specialized agent tools are emerging. They can make mistakes or take an unintended action. Give agents the least access required, add approval gates before sends, updates, purchases, or other external actions, keep logs, test in a low-risk environment, and require human review.

Workers who can set clear boundaries, supervise actions, review outputs, and stop unsafe workflows will bring useful operational judgment to agent-assisted work.

The Human Skills That Matter More Than Ever

Here's the counterintuitive reality: as AI gets better at doing more things, certain human skills become more valuable, not less.

Judgment

AI can generate a hundred options. It takes a human with experience and context to choose the right one. Good judgment - shaped by real experience and an understanding of people - cannot be replicated by a machine.

Relationships

Business runs on trust. Trust is built in human interactions: a lunch meeting, a difficult conversation handled with grace, a mentor who shows up when things get hard. No AI replaces that.

Creative Vision

AI is excellent at executing creative tasks once it knows what you want. But deciding what to make, what story to tell, what problem to solve - that creative vision is still fundamentally human.

Ethical Reasoning

As AI becomes more powerful, the decisions about how to use it matter more. People who think carefully about ethics, fairness, and consequences will be critical in every organization.

Communication

The ability to communicate clearly - to explain complex ideas simply, to inspire people, to navigate conflict - is more valuable in an AI-assisted world, not less.

Building a Personal Learning Habit

The half-life of specific job skills is shrinking. What matters more than any individual skill is the habit of learning.

- 16 Spend 15 minutes a week trying one new AI feature or tool. Set a calendar reminder.
- 17 Follow one or two AI newsletters to stay current without feeling overwhelmed. (See the Resources section for recommendations.)
- 18 After each significant AI-assisted task, ask yourself: what worked, what didn't, and what would I do differently?
- 19 Share what you learn with your team. Teaching something is the fastest way to master it - and it builds your reputation as the go-to person on AI.

How to Stay Valuable in an AI Workplace

As AI takes on more of the routine work, here's what will make you indispensable:

- 20 Learn to give clear instructions. The ability to direct AI precisely is a skill that will matter more every year.
- 21 Learn to check AI output. Critical thinking - knowing when something is wrong or incomplete - becomes more valuable as AI becomes more capable.
- 22 Know your company's data rules. Being the person who uses AI responsibly is a competitive advantage, not a limitation.
- 23 Build reusable workflows. People who systematize their AI use - prompt libraries, templates, saved projects - multiply their output over time.
- 24 Keep improving your human judgment. Experience, relationships, and contextual wisdom are things AI cannot replicate. Invest in them.

The Real Competitive Advantage

It is not about knowing every AI tool. It is about staying curious, adapting carefully, and continuously raising the quality of your work. Human judgment is what makes AI assistance useful and accountable.

Try This Today

Write down the three tasks in your job that take the most time and require the least unique expertise. Those are your first three AI targets. Pick one and use a prompt from the Bonus section to tackle it this week.

Bonus: 75 Ready-to-Use Prompts

Organized around Draft, Digest, Decide, Design, and Delegate

Use these prompts as starting points. Replace anything in [BRACKETS] with your specific details. The more specific you are, the better your results. Each prompt is a conversation starter - after the first response, iterate with follow-up instructions until you get exactly what you need.

Email (7 Prompts)

- 1 Write a professional email to [RECIPIENT] requesting [ACTION]. Context: [SITUATION].
- 2 Rewrite this email to sound more [formal / casual / warm / assertive]: [PASTE EMAIL].
- 3 Write a follow-up email to [RECIPIENT]. I sent [DOCUMENT] on [DATE] and haven't heard back.
- 4 Write a response to this complaint email: [PASTE EMAIL]. Tone: empathetic and solution-focused.
- 5 Write an email announcing [NEWS] to my team. Keep it clear, positive, and invite questions.
- 6 Write a cold outreach email introducing my [PRODUCT/SERVICE] to [TARGET AUDIENCE]. Keep it brief.
- 7 Write an apology email to [CLIENT/COLLEAGUE] about [SITUATION]. Be sincere and offer a solution.

Meetings (6 Prompts)

- 8 Create a [LENGTH]-minute meeting agenda for [MEETING TYPE]. Topics: [LIST TOPICS].
- 9 Turn these rough meeting notes into a clean summary with decisions and action items: [PASTE NOTES].

- 10 Write a follow-up email after today's meeting. Key decisions: [LIST]. Action items: [LIST].
- 11 Create a structured one-on-one meeting template for a manager and their direct report.
- 12 Write talking points for a difficult conversation I need to have with [PERSON] about [TOPIC].
- 13 Summarize this meeting transcript into the 5 most important takeaways: [PASTE TRANSCRIPT].

Reports and Documents (7 Prompts)

- 14 Write an executive summary of this report in one page: [PASTE REPORT].
- 15 Create a [TYPE] report using this structure: [OUTLINE]. Here is the data: [DATA].
- 16 Write a standard operating procedure for [PROCESS]. Format: numbered steps.
- 17 Write a business proposal for [PROJECT]. Audience: [DESCRIBE AUDIENCE].
- 18 Edit this document for clarity, flow, and conciseness: [PASTE DOCUMENT].
- 19 Write a risk assessment for [PROJECT]. Include likelihood and impact for each risk.
- 20 Create a policy document for [TOPIC]. Include: purpose, scope, policy details, and enforcement.

Excel and Data (6 Prompts)

- 21 Write Excel formulas to [DESCRIBE WHAT YOU NEED] in a spreadsheet where [DESCRIBE LAYOUT].
- 22 I have this data: [PASTE DATA]. What are the 3 most important insights, and what would you recommend?

- 23 Write a formula to clean up this data problem: [DESCRIBE PROBLEM].
- 24 What type of chart best shows [TYPE OF DATA] for [AUDIENCE], and why?
- 25 Explain what this formula does in plain English: [PASTE FORMULA].
- 26 Write a pivot table setup guide for [SPECIFIC USE CASE] in Excel.

HR and Management (7 Prompts)

- 27 Write a job description for [ROLE] at [TYPE OF COMPANY]. Include responsibilities, requirements, and a culture statement.
- 28 Using approved, job-related criteria and de-identified notes, draft a performance review for human manager and HR review. Identify unsupported conclusions and check language for consistency and bias: [APPROVED NOTES].
- 29 Create a 30-60-90 day onboarding plan for a new [ROLE].
- 30 Using our approved job criteria, draft 10 structured, job-related interview questions for [ROLE] that assess [SKILLS]. Exclude protected-characteristic inquiries and flag the set for HR or legal review.
- 31 Draft an email announcing a [POLICY CHANGE] to the team. Be clear, positive, and address likely concerns.
- 32 Using our approved policy and de-identified, documented job-performance facts, draft an improvement-plan outline for manager and HR review. Do not infer motive, disability, or protected status: [APPROVED FACTS].
- 33 Create a team meeting agenda focused on [TOPIC]. Include an icebreaker and discussion questions.

Marketing and Sales (7 Prompts)

- 34 Write 5 social media posts for [PLATFORM] about [PRODUCT/SERVICE/TOPIC]. Brand voice: [DESCRIBE].
- 35 Write a product description for [PRODUCT] targeting [AUDIENCE]. Highlight: [KEY BENEFITS].
- 36 Write a sales email introducing [PRODUCT/SERVICE] to [TARGET CUSTOMER]. Pain point: [PAIN POINT].
- 37 Create a content calendar for [MONTH] with 12 social media post ideas for [BUSINESS TYPE].
- 38 Write a homepage headline and subheadline for [BUSINESS] that communicates [VALUE PROPOSITION].
- 39 Write 3 variations of a call-to-action button for [GOAL]. Audience: [AUDIENCE].
- 40 Create a customer survey with 8 questions to measure satisfaction with [PRODUCT/SERVICE].

Customer Service (6 Prompts)

- 41 Write a response template for customers asking about [COMMON QUESTION].
- 42 Rewrite this customer complaint response to be warmer and more helpful: [PASTE RESPONSE].
- 43 Create a FAQ document for [PRODUCT/SERVICE] covering the 10 most common questions.
- 44 Write a script for handling an angry customer call about [ISSUE].
- 45 Write a follow-up email after resolving a customer issue to ensure their satisfaction.
- 46 Create a customer feedback request email to send after [EVENT/PURCHASE/INTERACTION].

Project Management (6 Prompts)

- 47 Create a project plan outline for [PROJECT]. Include phases, milestones, and dependencies.
- 48 Write a project status update for [PROJECT] for [AUDIENCE]. Status: [STATUS]. Issues: [ISSUES].
- 49 Identify the top 5 risks for this project: [DESCRIBE PROJECT]. Rate each by likelihood and impact.
- 50 Create a stakeholder communication plan for [PROJECT]. Stakeholders: [LIST].
- 51 Write a project kickoff meeting agenda for [PROJECT]. Team: [TEAM SIZE]. Duration: [LENGTH].
- 52 Convert this list of tasks into a prioritized action list using urgency and impact: [PASTE TASKS].

Research and Learning (6 Prompts)

- 53 Explain [COMPLEX TOPIC] as if I'm a smart person with no background in this field.
- 54 What are the top 5 trends in [INDUSTRY] right now, and what do they mean for [MY ROLE/BUSINESS]?
- 55 Compare [OPTION A] and [OPTION B] on [CRITERIA]. Help me make a decision.
- 56 Summarize this article in 3 sentences and tell me if the argument is well-supported: [PASTE ARTICLE].
- 57 Create a learning plan for me to become proficient in [SKILL] in [TIMEFRAME]. I currently know: [LEVEL].
- 58 What are the strongest arguments for and against [DECISION/POSITION]?

Small Business (7 Prompts)

- 59 Using our approved local template, draft a scope of work for [SERVICE/PROJECT]. Include what is included and excluded, and

flag permits, codes, warranties, payment terms, and change-order language for qualified review before client use.

- 60 Create a pricing strategy for [SERVICE]. Current cost: [COST]. Market rates: [INFO]. Target margin: [MARGIN].
- 61 Write the 'About Us' page for my [TYPE OF BUSINESS] that communicates our values and differentiators.
- 62 Write a monthly email newsletter for my [BUSINESS TYPE] customers. Topics: [TOPICS].
- 63 Create a customer referral program outline for [BUSINESS TYPE]. Include incentives and process.
- 64 Write a business plan executive summary for [BUSINESS IDEA]. Key details: [DETAILS].
- 65 Create the 10 most important questions I should be asking myself as I grow my [TYPE OF BUSINESS].

Writing and Editing (6 Prompts)

- 66 Edit this for clarity, grammar, and flow: [PASTE TEXT].
- 67 Rewrite this at a [GRADE LEVEL] reading level: [PASTE TEXT].
- 68 Make this more concise. Cut at least 30%: [PASTE TEXT].
- 69 Give me 10 stronger alternatives to this headline: [PASTE HEADLINE].
- 70 Write an introduction paragraph for an article about [TOPIC] that immediately grabs attention.
- 71 Review this argument and tell me where the logic is weak or where I need more evidence: [PASTE TEXT].

Safety and Quality (4 Prompts)

- 72 Review this planned AI task for privacy and confidentiality risks. Identify data that should be removed, minimized, or handled only in an approved system: [TASK AND DATA DESCRIPTION].

- 73 Audit this draft against the supplied primary sources. For each factual claim, identify the supporting source and passage; mark unsupported or conflicting claims for human review: [DRAFT AND SOURCES].
- 74 Review this document for accessibility and plain language. Check headings, reading order, link text, color-dependent meaning, image descriptions, tables, and reading level. Do not claim compliance; give me a human-review checklist: [DOCUMENT DESCRIPTION].
- 75 Design an approval workflow for this AI-assisted process using least privilege, test data, logging, named human reviewers, and approval gates before any message, update, purchase, or external action: [PROCESS].

Quick Reference

The Prompting Cheat Sheet

ROLE: "You are an experienced [ROLE]..."

TASK: "Write / Create / Summarize / Analyze / Edit..."

CONTEXT: "The situation is... The audience is... The background is..."

REQUIREMENTS: "Make sure to include... Avoid... Keep the tone..."

FORMAT: "Format this as a [DOCUMENT TYPE]. Use [bullets / paragraphs / table]..."

AI Vocabulary Glossary

- Prompt - The instructions or question you type into an AI tool.
- Hallucination - When AI confidently generates false or made-up information.
- Context window - A model's limited working capacity for instructions, conversation, and supplied content; actual usable limits and retention behavior vary.
- Iteration - The process of refining AI output through follow-up prompts.

- AI agent - An AI system that takes actions autonomously (browsing the web, sending emails, etc.).
- Large Language Model (LLM) - The underlying technology behind most conversational AI tools.
- Token - A unit of text (a variable unit of text; 'about three-quarters of an English word' is only a loose approximation) that AI uses to measure and process content.
- Temperature - A sampling control exposed in some tools and APIs; lower settings are often more predictable, but behavior varies by model.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Being too vague - always include role, task, context, requirements, and format.
- Sharing confidential or personal information with public AI tools.
- Copying AI output without reviewing it first.
- Treating AI as infallible - always verify important facts.
- Using one AI tool for everything when a specialized tool would work better.
- Not iterating - if the first response isn't right, ask AI to improve it.
- Giving up after one bad result - good prompting is a skill that takes practice.

AI Safety Checklist

- Did I avoid sharing confidential or personal information?
- Have I verified any specific facts, numbers, or statistics?
- Does this comply with my company's AI use policy?
- Does the content accurately represent my views and intentions?
- Have I reviewed and edited the output before using it?

Resources

Content last reviewed: August 2026. Product references are illustrative, not endorsements. Verify current features, plans, terms, and organizational approval before use.

Responsible AI, Privacy, and Safety

- NIST AI Risk Management Framework - <https://www.nist.gov/itl/ai-risk-management-framework>
- NIST Generative AI Profile - <https://doi.org/10.6028/NIST.AI.600-1>
- U.S. Copyright Office, Copyright and Artificial Intelligence - <https://www.copyright.gov/ai/>
- U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, HIPAA Business Associates - <https://www.hhs.gov/hipaa/for-professionals/privacy/guidance/business-associates/index.html>
- U.S. Department of Education, FERPA and Online Educational Tools - <https://studentprivacy.ed.gov/faq/i-want-use-online-tool-or-application-part-my-course-however-i-am-worried-it-violation-ferpa>
- OSHA Electrical Safety and Competent-Person Guidance - <https://www.osha.gov/electrical/hazards/aegcp>

Official Product Information

- OpenAI Help Center, Projects and Custom Instructions - <https://help.openai.com/>
- Anthropic Help Center, Projects - <https://support.anthropic.com/>
- Google Workspace Help, Gemini - <https://support.google.com/>
- Microsoft Support, Copilot - <https://support.microsoft.com/>

Further Reading

- *Co-Intelligence* by Ethan Mollick
- *The Coming Wave* by Mustafa Suleyman
- *Power and Prediction* by Ajay Agrawal, Joshua Gans, and Avi Goldfarb

Conclusion: Start Before You're Ready

Here's the truth: most people will read this book, find it genuinely useful, feel motivated - and then not change much about how they work.

Not because they didn't learn anything. But because starting something new feels awkward and uncertain, and it's easier to fall back into old habits. Don't let that be you.

You don't have to overhaul your entire workflow tomorrow. Start with one task. Just one. The next email you have to write - try using AI for the draft. See what happens. It probably won't be perfect. That's fine. Edit it, learn from it, try again.

With consistent, careful practice, the workflow should begin to feel more natural. Keep only the uses that produce dependable value after review.

Your 5D System Is Already Built

You now have everything you need to apply the 5D Work System to your job. Look back at your work week. Find one task in each category:

- One thing you Draft regularly - an email, a report, a document
- One thing you Digest regularly - a meeting, a report, an inbox
- One decision you could think through better with AI as a partner
- One thing you Design repeatedly - a checklist, a workflow, a template
- One thing you could Delegate to a saved prompt forever

Start there. Five tasks. Five prompts. A small setup investment that may save time each week. That's the system. It's simple because simple is what gets used.

Build Your Own AI Toolkit

As you work through the tools and techniques in this book, start building your personal collection:

- A prompt library - your saved prompts for the tasks you do most often
- A preferred tool shortlist - the two or three AI tools that fit your workflow best
- A template library - documents you use regularly that can be semi-automated

This toolkit is yours. It grows with you. And it becomes more valuable the more you add to it.

Keep Learning

AI is a fast-moving field. What's true today may be different in six months. The specific tools will change. The underlying skill - knowing how to direct AI, how to evaluate its output, how to integrate it into your work - those skills transfer across any tool.

Stay curious. Experiment. Make mistakes. Share what you learn.

The workers who thrive in the coming years won't be the ones who feared AI, or the ones who blindly trusted it. They'll be the ones who learned to work with it thoughtfully - combining human judgment with AI capability to do things that neither could do alone.

That's you.

Draft. Digest. Decide. Design. Delegate.

Now go make some time back.

About the Author

Patrick Thomas is an author, veteran, facilities management professional, and technology enthusiast focused on making artificial intelligence practical and approachable for everyday people.

His AI Guide Series was created for readers who want clear explanations, useful examples, and real-world ways to use AI without technical jargon or unnecessary complexity.

Patrick writes practical guides for people who want to understand new technology, use it responsibly, and apply it to work, home, safety, learning, and everyday problem-solving.

Also in the AI Guide Series

- **Book 1 - AI Won't Replace You:** But Someone Using AI Might
- **Book 2 - AI for Everyday Life:** 50 Practical Ways to Save Time, Solve Problems, and Think Better with AI
- **Book 3 - AI at Work:** Increase Productivity and Get More Done Without Working Longer Hours
- **Book 4 - AI Safety and Scam Prevention:** Identify Scams, Spot Misinformation, and Stay Safe in an AI World
- **Book 5 - AI for Veterans:** Better Understand Benefits, Healthcare, and Government Services
- **Special Booklet - The AI Gold Rush:** Why So Many People Are Selling AI Wealth - and What They're Really Selling

Build your AI skills one guide at a time.